

CHRISTIAN RATHMANN

Prof. Dr. · Linguist · Sign Language Researcher
Humboldt-Universität zu Berlin

Department of Deaf Studies and
Sign Language Interpreting

Unter den Linden 6
10099 Berlin · Germany

christian.rathmann@hu-berlin.de

RESEARCH PROFILE

Linguist specializing in sign languages and their structural, sociolinguistic, educational, translational and societal dimensions. Research connects linguistic analysis with multilingual Deaf Communities, Deaf Studies, language rights and planning, professional interpreting and translation, and sign language learning, teaching and assessment. A recurring focus is the development of sustainable research infrastructures, educational resources and international collaborations.

RESEARCH AREAS

Sign Language Linguistics

Structure, grammar, morphosyntax, semantics, argument structure, agreement, corpus linguistics

Deaf Studies

Deaf-centered research, Deaf Communities, cultural knowledge, community agency and language rights

Interpreting & Translation

Interpreting, translation and mediation, professionalization, Deaf professionals, quality and multilingual practice

Sign Language Sociolinguistics

Variation and change, multilingualism, language contact, International Sign Language (IntSL)

Language Policy & Planning

Right to language, recognition, maintenance, transmission, planning and community-led standardization

Learning, Teaching & Assessment

CEFR, curricula, teacher professionalization, language assessment and equitable learning opportunities

ACADEMIC POSITIONS

- 2017–** **Professor and Head, Department of Deaf Studies and Sign Language Interpreting** | Humboldt-Universität zu Berlin
Academic and organizational leadership; curriculum development; research and doctoral supervision; externally funded projects and international cooperation.
- 2008–2017** **Professor and Head, Sign Language and Sign Language Interpreting** | Universität Hamburg
Leadership of teaching, research and infrastructure development at the Institute of German Sign Language and Communication of the Deaf (IDGS).
- 2006–2007** **Lecturer in Deaf Studies** | University of Bristol
- 2005–2006** **Assistant Professor in American Sign Language Education** | The Ohio State University
- 2000–2004** **Lecturer** | The University of Texas at Austin

EDUCATION & QUALIFICATIONS

- 2005** **PhD in Linguistics** | The University of Texas at Austin
Dissertation: Event Structure in American Sign Language.
- 2000** **M.A. in Linguistics** | The University of Texas at Austin
Thesis: The Optionality of Agreement Phrase: Evidence from German Sign Language.
- 2011–** **State-certified interpreter and translator** | Germany
Working languages: German Sign Language (DGS), International Sign Language (IntSL), American Sign Language (ASL), German and English.

RESEARCH LEADERSHIP, INFRASTRUCTURE & TRANSFER

2009–2017	Project Lead, DGS Corpus Project Academy of Sciences and Humanities in Hamburg Long-term corpus and research infrastructure for German Sign Language (DGS).
since 05/2018	Chair, Scientific Committee, DGS Corpus Project Academy of Sciences and Humanities in Hamburg Scientific governance and long-term development of the DGS Corpus.
since 2024	Founder and Lead, Estonian Sign Language Research Centre (EVKUR) Tallinn University Research on Estonian Sign Language structure and use, language resources, teaching and assessment, language policy and early-career capacity building.
2024–2027	Project Coordinator, DeafSign European Centre for Modern Languages / Council of Europe Unlocking educational opportunities in sign languages in Europe; multilingualism, educational equity, teacher competences and Deaf learners with refugee and immigration backgrounds.
2016–2019	Project Coordinator, ProSign European Centre for Modern Languages / Council of Europe CEFR-based sign language teaching, learning and assessment; proficiency descriptors, curriculum development and teacher competences. Project member 2011–2016.
current	DMIT – Deaf Mediators, Interpreters and Translators Research initiative Professional roles, training pathways, recognition, employment, collaboration and Deaf-led professional governance.
since 2017	Chair, Focus Team Accessibility, Fachstelle Teilhabeberatung BMAS-funded national structure Quality assurance and development of accessible communication, especially in DGS; translation and review processes, accessible event formats and institutional consultation.
since 2022/23	VisuoLab & SignBank 2.0 International research infrastructure Multilingual and multimodal resources for sign language documentation, learning and teaching, Deaf Studies, translation and interpreting.

ACADEMIC ENGAGEMENT & EDITORIAL WORK

- Editorial Board, Sign Language & Linguistics (since 2007).
- Associate Editor, language sections of Frontiers in Psychology / Frontiers in Communication (since 2021).
- Editorial Board, Journal of Deaf Studies and Deaf Education (since 2024).
- Board Member, Sign Language and Linguistics Society (2014–2022).
- Co-editor with Christopher Stone, Robert Adam and Ronice Müller de Quadros of The Routledge Handbook of Sign Language Translation and Interpreting (2022).
- Co-editor with Richard P. Meier and Aaron Shield of the Frontiers Research Topic Modality and Language Acquisition (2023).
- Member, State Examination Committee for sign language interpreting and translation in Hesse (since 2010).
- National and international standardization work in interpreting and translation (since 2022).
- Collaboration with Deaf organizations and European institutions on sign language rights, minority-language protection and policy implementation.

SELECTED PROJECTS & INTERNATIONAL COOPERATION

- STEMSiL (Erasmus+, 2023–2025) – international cooperation on STEM learning in sign languages.
- Free Technology Signs (Erasmus+, 2021–2024) – multilingual technology-sign resources and international professional networks.
- DESIGNS – Deaf Employment for Sign Language Users in the EU (Erasmus+, 2017–2019) – employment access and professional participation.
- Summer School of Sign Language Studies – international early-career research, mentoring and capacity building.

SELECTED PUBLICATIONS & EDITORIAL PROJECTS

Selected to reflect the interconnected research areas of the website; a complete and current publication record is available through Google Scholar.

- 2026** Rathmann, C. *A language or not a language? International Sign Language in multilingual ecologies*. Zenodo prepublication. <https://doi.org/10.5281/zenodo.22075375>
- 2026** Quadros, R. M. de, & Rathmann, C. *Variation and stability of lexical items in International Sign Language*. *The Linguistic Review*, 43(1), 1–35. <https://doi.org/10.1515/tlr-2025-0041>
- 2025** Rathmann, C., de Quadros, R. M., & da Silva, J. B. *Exploring ethical discussion in sign language research*. *Sign Language Studies*, 26(1), 169–211. <https://doi.org/10.1353/sls.2025.a981202>
- 2025** Rathmann, C., & Romanek, P. Z. *AI-generated sign languages (AI-SL): Opportunities, challenges, recommendations and legal frameworks*. In F. Venade (Ed.), *Sign Language in the Era of Artificial Intelligence*, 167–198. European Union of the Deaf.
- 2024** Rathmann, C., Geißler, T., Dannenbeck, C., & Fries, S. *Diskurse im Dialog: Zur Standortbestimmung von Deaf Studies und Disability Studies in Deutschland heute*. *Gemeinsam leben*, 32(1), 5–17. <https://doi.org/10.3262/GL2401005>
- 2023** Meier, R. P., Rathmann, C., & Shield, A. (Eds.). *Modality and language acquisition: How does the channel through which language is expressed affect how children and adults are able to learn?* *Frontiers Media SA*. <https://doi.org/10.3389/978-2-8325-4150-0>
- 2022** Stone, C., Adam, R., Müller de Quadros, R., & Rathmann, C. (Eds.). *The Routledge Handbook of Sign Language Translation and Interpreting*. Routledge. <https://doi.org/10.4324/9781003019664>
- 2022** Rathmann, C., & Müller de Quadros, R. *International Sign Language: Sociolinguistic Aspects*. Editora Arara Azul. <https://doi.org/10.29327/5198879>
- 2022** Humphries, T., Mathur, G., Napoli, D. J., Padden, C., & Rathmann, C. *Deaf children need rich language input from the start: Support in advising parents*. *Children*, 9(11), 1609. <https://doi.org/10.3390/children9111609>
- 2021** Quadros, R. M. de, & Rathmann, C. *Sign language standardization*. In W. Ayres-Bennett & J. Bellamy (Eds.), *The Cambridge Handbook of Language Standardization*, 765–788. <https://doi.org/10.1017/9781108559249.030>
- 2016** Leeson, L., van den Bogaerde, B., Rathmann, C., & Haug, T. *Sign Languages and the Common European Framework of Reference for Languages*. European Centre for Modern Languages of the Council of Europe.
- 2013** Humphries, T., Kushalnagar, P., Mathur, G., Napoli, D. J., Padden, C., Rathmann, C., & Smith, S. *The right to language*. *The Journal of Law, Medicine & Ethics*, 41(4), 872–884. <https://doi.org/10.1111/jlme.12097>
- 2011** Rathmann, C., & Mathur, G. *A featural approach to verb agreement in signed languages*. *Theoretical Linguistics*, 37(3–4), 197–208. <https://doi.org/10.1515/thli.2011.015>
- 2002** Rathmann, C., & Mathur, G. *Is verb agreement the same cross-modally?* In R. P. Meier, K. Cormier & D. Quinto-Pozos (Eds.), *Modality and Structure in Signed and Spoken Languages*, 370–404. Cambridge University Press.

ACADEMIC PROFILES

Google Scholar: scholar.google.com/citations?user=BxmGW-cAAAAJ

ORCID: 0000-0001-9191-7612

LinkedIn: [christian-rathmann-2a41113b4](https://www.linkedin.com/in/christian-rathmann-2a41113b4)

Humboldt-Universität zu Berlin: [Department profile](#)

ResearchGate will be added to the website once the exact public profile URL is confirmed.